

CP Exam – August 2025

Instructions: Answer 3 of the 7 questions below. Choose questions that show the depth and breadth of your knowledge. In incorporating the existing literature into your answers, do not simply summarize the readings but engage with the implications of their theoretical framework and the empirical findings for the question at hand. Each answer comprises one-third of the exam grade.

- You have 7.5 hours to complete the exam.
- This exam is not open-book, but you can use up to 30 single-spaced pages of notes using standard 12-point font size and a clean copy of the reading list.
- The exam has a strict 21-page limit (double-space, 12 font).
- If you cite sources that are not on the reading list, please provide a full citation at the end of your answer. This reference list for external sources will not count against the exam's 21-page limit.

1. Authoritarian elites often persist after transitions to democracy. Under what conditions are such continuities more likely to occur? Discuss at least two domains in which elite persistence is observable (e.g., legal, economic, bureaucratic), and provide examples from two national contexts to illustrate your claims.

2. What is the relationship between state-building and nation-building? Are these processes mutually reinforcing, independent, or in tension with one another?

3. Our Comparative Politics Reading List divides the literature between comparative political behavior ("Political Parties, Participation, and Mobilization") and contentious politics ("Social Movements, Protest, and Revolution"). Discuss the connection between these literatures. Are institutional (e.g., voter mobilization, legislative bargaining) and extra-institutional (e.g., rebellion, civil disobedience) political strategies complements, substitutes, or some combination?

4. Compare and contrast the factors that contribute to the development of state taxation as compared to the conditions that lead to the development of the welfare state. In your assessment, are the literatures on taxation and the welfare state sufficiently in dialogue with one another? Critically assess the extent to which new insights can be derived by comparing the arguments made in each of these two literatures.

5. To what extent are the factors that lead to democratization (using a minimalist institutional definition of electoral democracy) similar or distinct from the factors that lead

to increased political accountability to voters within political systems that hold competitive elections?

6. A prominent theme in the literatures on protest, rebellion, and revolution is the puzzle of collective action. Individual participation in contentious political activity is costly and risky, while the benefits of mobilization tend to be diffuse and shared with those who do not participate directly. How have scholars made sense of this puzzle? Discuss at least two theories that have been forwarded to explain individual participation in contentious politics. What can each theory explain or not explain?

7. Comparative politics research often faces the challenge of generalizing from context-specific findings. What are scope conditions, and how are they formulated? Discuss alternative approaches to generalization in comparative research, drawing on examples from the reading list to illustrate how scholars navigate the tension between context sensitivity and theoretical abstraction.